Alessandro Balbina

Ph.D. Student in Economics and Business

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Research Interests

Tourism Economics, Sustainable Tourism, Artificial Intelligence in Destination Management, Econometrics, Spatial Analysis & GIS.

Education

Ph.D. in Economics and Business (41st Cycle) **November 2025 · Present**
University of Cagliari, Italy | Department of Economics and Business
Focus: Use of artificial intelligence by tourists for planning and booking travel experiences, focusing on AI chatbots using mixed qualitative/quantitative methodologies.
Supervisor: Prof. Cinzia Dessì | Co-supervisor: Prof. Ivan Etzo

M.Sc. in Sustainable Tourism Management and Monitoring 2022 · 2025
University of Cagliari, Italy
Graduation Grade: 110/110 cum laude
Thesis: *Tourism data, sustainability and shadow tourism estimates. Case study of the municipality of Cagliari.*

B.Sc. in Communication Sciences 2017 · 2022
University of Cagliari, Italy
Graduation Grade: 106/110
Thesis: *Rebrand and social media strategy: The case of the agricultural company "Opuntia".*

Conference Papers & Abstracts

- **Balbina, A.**, Vincis, A., & Dessì, C. (2026). "Driving Sustainable Destinations through Digital Transformation: A Qualitative Inquiry into Local SMEs in Sardinia." *6th ICEM Conference* (Conference Abstract).
- Vincis, A., Tedde, D., **Balbina, A.**, & Dessì, C. (2026). "AI Literacy as a Hiring Signal in Project Management Recruitment." *Sinergie-SIMA Management Conference 2026* (Short Paper, forthcoming).
- Vincis, A., Dessì, C., **Balbina, A.**, & Succa, A. (2026). "Productivity patterns of family vs non-family firms under stability and crisis." *Sinergie-SIMA Management Conference 2026* (Short Paper, forthcoming).

Working Papers & Research in Progress

- **Balbina, A.** "Adoption of Artificial Intelligence by Tourists: A Literature Review." (In progress, exploring AI applications in trip planning, destination research, and travel bookings).
- Dessì, C., Vincis, A., & **Balbina, A.** "People Management in AI-Enabled SMEs: A Human-Centered Capability Perspective." Book chapter to appear in the series *Innovation in Human Centered Sustainability: Human Centered Sustainability in the AI Age.*

Presentations & Talks

- Dessì, C. & **Balbina, A.** (2026). "Cineturismo, immaginario audiovisivo e territorio: dalla letteratura internazionale al caso locale de L'Isola di Pietro." Talk presented at the event *Ogni film è un viaggio*, Società Umanitaria, Cagliari, Italy.

Honors & Awards

Outstanding Young Scholar Reviewer 2026
Sinergie-SIMA Management Conference

Professional Experience

Consultant for Local Development and Tourism (Apprenticeship)
Rete Gaia, Sardinia, Italy (Hybrid) Apr 2025 – Jan 2026

- Provided consultancy in the design and implementation of sustainable local development initiatives.
- Carried out territorial economic animation activities.
- Conducted demand analysis and developed tourism offer products.
- Provided consultancy, territorial development, and marketing support for *Sardinian Roots*, a project focused on diaspora/roots tourism.
- Provided marketing consultancy and created online and offline content for Italea Sardegna.
- Competencies: Project Management, Python (Programming Language).

Data Analyst (Internship)
Comune di Cagliari, Cagliari, Italy Sep 2024 – Dec 2024

- Curricular internship at the Tourism Office of the Municipality of Cagliari.
- Competencies: Data Analysis, Public Administration.

University Tutor – B.Sc. in Economics and Business Management
University of Cagliari, Cagliari, Italy (Hybrid) Nov 2023 – Sep 2024

- Tutorial, didactic-integrative, preparatory, and remedial activities, as defined under Art. 3 of Ministerial Decree No. 1047/2017.
- Organized and supervised TOLC admission testing.
- Automated enrollment, course-transfer, and CFU (credit) certification processes for the B.Sc. in Economics and Business Management.

Research Contributor | Sardinian Roots Project (e.INS) 2025

- Contributed to designing tailored tourism experiences for the global Sardinian diaspora, merging local heritage promotion with sustainable tourism strategies.

Other Experience

Airport Ground Handling Agent (Addetto di scalo aeroportuale – Seasonal)
SOGAERDYN Società per Azioni, Cagliari, Italy Jun 2018 – Oct 2022

- Provided passenger reception and assistance, check-in procedures, boarding operations, and finalization of airport operations (Accoglienza passeggeri, procedure di check-in, operazioni di imbarco e finalizzazione operazioni aeroportuali).
- Worked seasonally across four periods (total duration of 4 years and 5 months):
  - Season 2018: June – September
  - Season 2019: May – October
  - Season 2021: July – October
  - Season 2022: May – October
- Specialized software and systems used: Altéa Suite, iPort.

Scout Leader | AGESCI (Italian Catholic Guides and Scouts Association) 2018 – Present

- Guided young scouts, organized wilderness treks, and designed educational activities on environmental stewardship and civic consciousness.

Skills

- **Programming & Data Analysis:** Python (Data Scraping, Econometrics), Geographic Information Systems (GIS), Open Data Mapping.
- **Languages:** Italian (Native), Sardinian (Native), English (Fluent).

Certifications & Licenses

- **IBSEN Entrepreneurship Workshop Series** | IBSEN Network Issued: Feb 2025
  - Associated Competencies: Entrepreneurship (Imprenditorialità), Sustainability (Sostenibilità).

- **BLSD – Basic Life Support Defibrillation** | Ircomunità A.p.s. Issued: Jun 2022 | Expires: Jun 2026
  – Credential ID: 20220000235718.